Seminar — Storia Digitale 2026/27

Dipartimento di Scienze Sociali · Università degli Studi di Napoli Federico II · Aula II-2, Vico Monte della Pietà 1

Prof. Benedikt Perak · Cultural Complexity Lab, University of Rijeka · 21 e 22 ottobre 2026, ore 15.00

What these two afternoons are for

One argument across two days: a historical source becomes analysable only after it is turned into a record with an identifier, a field structure and a location — and every one of those three steps is an interpretive act that has to stay visible in the final map. Day 1 does the transformation on paper and in a live map. Day 2 opens the machine that did it, and shows where it lies to us.

Day 1 — Wednesday 21 October, 15.00–17.00 · From the archive to the map

☐ **15.00** **Three objects, not one**

The source (what the archive holds), the datum (what we can compute on), the model (what generalises). Most failures in digital history come from confusing the three. Ten minutes of examples, no theory.

☐ **15.15** **Digitisation is translation**

Scan → OCR/HTR → normalisation → metadata → stable identifier. Each arrow loses something and adds something. Show one page of a 1980s questionnaire turning into a row of 27 columns: the anecdote that survives, the handwriting that does not.

☐ **15.35** **Geolocalisation: place is not a coordinate**

Every location claim carries an uncertainty class — exact address, street, quarter, city, unknown. Naples makes this concrete: Piazza Bellini, the Decumani, Sanità and Vomero are units of memory before they are units of geometry. Gazetteers (GeoNames, Pleiades, OSM) do not solve this; they only give us a vocabulary to argue with.

☐ **15.55** **Live map: Naples 1980, musical memory — a probe, not a survey**

Open the map with the students. Cluster by type of place, read two popups aloud, switch on the heat layer. Then say plainly what this is: 429 responses written by two language models, not by four hundred Neapolitans. It is a probe of what a model produces when asked to remember a city — and the map is the instrument that makes the difference visible.

☐ **16.25** **The honest answer, with numbers**

1,716 place records, 1,555 of them placed in a quarter — but only 1,304 distinct names, and the two models agree on just 18 of them. Names like Il Gabbiano, Il Covo, Il Tunnel, Disco Market: plausible Italian venues, not documented Neapolitan ones. If we keep only what each model repeats at least three times — its stable memory — 293 points remain, a fifth of the map. So the honest reading is not 'Naples had these places'. It is: a model asked to remember a city produces fluent, confident, largely non-overlapping invention, and one model flags 61 % of its own places as uncertain while the other flags 25 %. That difference is a measurable fact about models; the city is still elsewhere.

☐ **16.45** **Exercise: geolocate one place together**

A student names a 1980s venue. We decide, publicly, what class of evidence we have for placing it, and what we would have to read to move it one class up — from quarter to street. Fifteen minutes, no laptops.

Close: the map is not the answer, it is the argument made visible — and an argument shows its own seams.

Day 2 — Thursday 22 October, 15.00–17.00 · From the map to the analysis

☐ **15.00** **Recap in one slide of paper**

Yesterday's three objects; today we open the middle one. The dataset behind the map: one sheet, 429 rows, 27 columns, three tabs — data, questions, legend. Everything reproducible from it.

☐ **15.10** **How a text becomes a table without a human typing it**

Prompt → structured output (JSON) → validation → merge. The pipeline in the Colab: generation, extraction of place names, mapping of quarter to coordinates, rendering. We walk the twelve cells in order and break one on purpose, to see what a silent failure looks like.

☐ **15.40 What synthetic respondents can and cannot prove**

First the confession, before anyone asks: 1,304 distinct names for 1,716 records, and 18 shared between the two models. The data are a stress test of the method, not a record of the city. They cannot tell us what Neapolitans remember. They can tell us what a model has absorbed about a city, which is a different and measurable object: distribution over quarters, type of venue, confidence self-report, agreement between models. Present the 2 % overlap as the finding, not as a defect of the method — it is evidence about training data, and it sets the price of using models as sources.

☐ **16.10 Hands-on: change one parameter, watch the map move**

Each student opens the Colab and runs all cells (three minutes on a phone). Then: add one quarter to the coordinate table, or change the type classifier for one venue, and see how many points move and how the heat layer reacts. What moves is the interpretation; what stays is the source.

☐ **16.40 What a historian would demand before believing any of this**

A citation per point, a date of observation, a distinction between attested and inferred, and a way to delete a claim without deleting the row. Compare with ARCHAEODIGIT and the Fulfinum Mirine material: same pipeline, different evidence class.

Close: the deliverable of digital history is not a map. It is a pipeline someone else can rerun and disagree with.

Materials and links

Interactive map (live): https://bperak.github.io/napoli-1980-map/

Colab notebook (12 cells, runs as is): https://colab.research.google.com/drive/1OIh0W0HS9BAuD0rX8Oia5Jq4JuD9WpcK

Dataset — 429 questionnaires:
https://docs.google.com/spreadsheets/d/1BRatPazDttqVVxpFfEBxuOd4ddiA9_mDleRNDJQtQYU/edit

Offline copies of both maps (PNG) and the whole notebook are in the shared Drive folder, in case the Aula Wi-Fi refuses to cooperate.

Before leaving the office

- ☐ Laptop charged + HDMI/USB-C adapter for Aula II-2
- ☐ Both maps downloaded locally (Drive folder) — do not rely on the network
- ☐ Map open in a tab, zoom set on the Centro storico, heat layer off
- ☐ Colab opened once on your own account so it is warm
- ☐ One printed copy of this page per day, with the checkboxes

If the conversation goes well

Two concrete follow-ups worth proposing to Prof. D'Alessio: (1) the students' own questionnaires geolocated in the same pipeline, as a graded exercise — real memory against model memory on one map; (2) a joint session with ARCHAEODIGIT where the same method meets an attested archaeological dataset. Both are cheap to run and both produce something publishable.